



Trump suggests taking over the District

Attack raises alarms; he asserts that city leaders aren't effective on crime

BY PAUL SCHWARTZMAN, PETER HERMANN, EMILY DAVIES AND JENNY GATHRIGHT

President Donald Trump, in his sharpest attack on D.C.'s right to self-governance since returning to power, said the federal government "should take over" management of the city because he believes its leaders are not reducing crime, cleaning up graffiti and dismantling homeless encampments.

"I think that we should run it strong, run it with law and order, make it absolutely, flawlessly beautiful," Trump told reporters aboard Air Force One late Wednesday.

His remarks prompted a swift response from local leaders in the federal enclave, including Mayor Muriel E. Bowser (D), who said Thursday that the president's impressions of the city are out-of-date and rooted in the "covid environment" that he left in 2021 at the end of his first term.

The mayor, at an already scheduled news conference, refrained from directly criticizing Trump and repeated that she would focus on their "shared priorities" to improve the city. Yet, in her most expansive remarks since his inauguration about the threat of a federal takeover, Bowser said Trump's

SEE D.C. ON A5

Presidential fellows: Trump ends federal leadership program. **B1**

JFK library: Following Trump cuts, Boston center lets people in free. **C1**

Hamas returns four bodies, but IDF says one does not belong to a hostage



JEHAD ALSHRAFI/AP

Palestinians gather as Hamas fighters escort Red Cross vehicles carrying remains that the militants said belonged to four Israeli hostages — a mother, her two children and a retired journalist — in Gaza on Thursday. But the Israel Defense Forces later said the remains did not include a forensic match for the mother. **Story, A11**

President is expected to wrest control of USPS

BY JACOB BOGAGE

President Donald Trump is preparing to dissolve the leadership of the U.S. Postal Service and absorb the independent mail agency into his administration, potentially throwing the 250-year-old mail provider and trillions of dollars of e-commerce transactions into turmoil.

Trump is expected to issue an executive order as soon as this week to fire the members of the

Postal Service's governing board and place the agency under the control of the Commerce Department and Secretary Howard Lutnick, according to six people familiar with the plans, who spoke on the condition of anonymity out of fear of reprisals.

The board is planning to fight Trump's order, three of those people told The Washington Post. In an emergency meeting Thursday, the board retained outside counsel and gave in-

structions to sue the White House if the president were to remove members of the board or attempt to alter the agency's independent status.

Two of the group's GOP members — Derek Kan, a former Trump administration official, and Mike Duncan, a former chair of the Republican National Committee — were not in attendance, according to a person familiar with the gathering. The two did not immediately respond to re-

quests for comment.

Trump's order to place the Commerce Department in charge of the Postal Service would probably violate federal law, according to postal experts. Another executive order earlier this week instructed independent agencies to align more closely with the White House, though that order is likely to prompt court challenges and the Postal Service by law is generally ex-

SEE USPS ON A8

Occupancy of offices hits a high in big cities

Average of 54.2% filled at end of January, marking largest share since 2020

BY DANIELLE ABRIL

Eric Matzke used to be able to find a seat on the train when commuting to his office in Chinatown in downtown D.C. But on a recent day in February, he stood alongside the crowd of government and business workers who have steadily trickled back to their offices.

"I remember getting drinks after work in 2021, and it still felt like you were human furniture in a way. Now, it feels like you're a part of something," he said, noting that the growing number of in-person workers has injected some liveliness back into the city.

With employer mandates across the country taking effect, the number of people coming into an office is at its highest point since the pandemic, according to data released from property management company Kastle Systems. During the final week of January, office occupancy — or the percentage of office space that is filled — hit a record-

SEE OFFICES ON A15



MELINA MARA/THE WASHINGTON POST

Miriam Schulman's house still stands, but she isn't sure when it will be safe to move back in.

Relief, then a hard reality

Their homes survived the L.A. fires, but little around them remains

BY REIS THEBAULT

LOS ANGELES — First, they felt relief. The firestorm had blown through their neighborhoods and leveled entire communities, but somehow — miraculously — their homes still stood. Then, reality set in.

For residents whose homes narrowly survived the Palisades and Eaton fires last month, what initially seemed like good fortune has quickly given way to grief and uncertainty. One of the most destructive disasters in Los Angeles history spared their properties, but the lucky ones now find themselves reckoning with what remains all around them: lonely moonscapes

that look nothing like the places they once loved.

Most won't be able to return for good anytime soon, and the long recovery period means their isolation could persist for years to come.

"This won't be the same community that it was — or even a new version of it — for a very long time," said Grace Dzilenski as she loaded her car with belongings recovered from the home she shared with her fiancé in a hilly part of Pacific Palisades. Their low-slung house was intact, but the rest of their street looked like a scene from a war movie.

"You hate to sound like an ingrate, but there's something bittersweet about your house being

SEE FIRES ON A20

One month in, a tireless pursuit of more power

President maneuvers to build muscular executive beyond historical bounds

BY NAFTALI BENDAVID

In just one month in office, President Donald Trump has made it clear that he sees the presidency in starkly different terms from virtually any of his 44 predecessors.

He is not the first president to push the bounds of his authority. Andrew Johnson fired a Cabinet secretary in defiance of Congress. Franklin D. Roosevelt tried to pack the Supreme Court. Richard M. Nixon dismissed a prosecutor who threatened his hold on power.

But to a degree possibly unprecedented in the country's nearly 250 years, Trump is barreling through the executive branch with the conviction that it is his to rule alone, no matter the laws Congress has enacted — even if that means destroying agencies, intervening in the justice system or granting enormous authority to a wealthy donor.

That is not how most presidents have seen a job that the Constitution arguably defines — beyond its military and diplomatic duties — as essentially doing what Congress tells him, saying he must "take Care that the Laws be faithfully executed."

"We are in a new kind of presi-

dency with Donald Trump," said H.W. Brands, a historian at the University of Texas at Austin. "He is trying to make the presidency like a CEO position in a corporation."

Trump is the first president who is essentially ignoring the existence of Congress, added Brands, a biographer of Andrew Jackson, Franklin D. Roosevelt and Ronald Reagan. "Presidents before Trump have not led with executive orders — they have fallen back on executive orders when Congress wouldn't do what they wanted it to do," Brands said. "But they all agreed that it was better to get Congress to pass legislation than to issue an executive order."

Trump's first month is striking not just because of the president's actions, but also because a significant number of Americans and members of Congress are applauding his aggressive approach to the job. The country appears to

SEE TRUMP ON A7



Kash Patel takes helm at FBI

The close Trump ally has called for profound changes at the agency. **A4**

Compliance: Trump close to line of defying judges, experts say. **A9**

IN THE NEWS

McConnell won't seek reelection The Kentucky Republican's decades-long career in the Senate will end in 2026, he said. **A9**

Legacy admissions Georgetown students helped advance proposed legislation that, if approved by the D.C. Council, would end the practice at some local private universities. **B1**

THE NATION
New York's governor said she won't remove Mayor Eric Adams from office "at this time." **A2**
The CDC has been directed to postpone a meeting of its vaccine advisory panel. **A2**

THE WORLD
The tomb of an ancient pharaoh, King Thutmose II, has been unearthed in Egypt. **A11**
A U.S. envoy met with Ukraine's Volodymyr Zelensky amid the nations' war of words. **A13**

THE ECONOMY
A sweeping lawsuit filed by New York state accuses major e-cigarette companies of fueling a public health crisis. **A15**
A federal judge declined to pause the Trump administration's moves to fire thousands of federal workers. **A16**

THE REGION
In a second case tied to an agency that awards grants for violence interruption, a former top D.C. official was charged with bribery. **B1**
The owner of a Northwest D.C. rowhouse where two tenants died in a fire was found guilty of murder. **B1**

STYLE
A museum dedicated to go-go, D.C.'s home-grown, half-century-old dance-music genre, opened in Anacostia. **C1**
WEEKEND
In Dupont Circle, 10 restaurants offer American classics, Sichuan cooking, Oaxacan specialties and more.

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